

THE ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA CHECKLIST

8 rewrite patterns for turning a criterion that sounds fine into one that's actually testable.

WHEN A CRITERION SOUNDS FINE

"System should process the trade correctly."

Could two engineers, working alone, build the same thing from it? If the answer depends on both of them guessing the same way, it isn't finished yet.

1 OBSERVABLE, NOT TRUE

"Correctly" is a feeling everyone shares until they don't. Say what should be observable.

2 GIVEN / WHEN / THEN

Each part does a job. Skip the Given and "when X, then Y" could mean almost anything.

3 WRITE THE NEGATIVE PATH

A criterion that only describes success hasn't said what failure looks like.

4 CHECK THE BOUNDARY

Nobody breaks software in the middle of a range. They break it at the edge.

5 DEFINE ERROR BEHAVIOUR

"Show error if invalid" describes that something happens, not what.

6 RULE VS. CRITERION

One describes how the business works. The other describes how the system proves it.

7 KILL VAGUE ADJECTIVES

Correctly, properly, quickly, appropriately, normally, efficiently, user-friendly.

8 ONE CRITERION, ONE BEHAVIOUR

A criterion proving four things at once can't fail cleanly when one breaks.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA QUALITY CHECKLIST

☐ Observable

☐ Specific

☐ Happy path covered

☐ Boundary conditions considered

☐ Data expectations clear

☐ Testable

☐ Business rule understood

☐ Negative path covered

☐ Error behaviour defined

☐ No vague adjectives

REMEMBER

"Correctly" is not a requirement. It's a placeholder for one.

Every acceptance criterion should survive one test: could two engineers, working alone, build the same thing from it?